

Russia: Duma election tests system capacity

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【メール原文】

September parliamentary election will serve as a loyalty test and a succession-planning mechanism. The State Duma has passed no independently negotiated legislation in two decades, and this election will not change that. Neither will it change the composition of the legislature in any significant way. Yet the vote is still worth watching for two reasons.

Russia

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Duma election will test bureaucratic capacity and offer succession clues

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Although United Russia is guaranteed to win an orchestrated majority in the 18-20 September parliamentary election, the overall result matters less than what the process reveals about the system's stability and its ability to deliver a result for the Kremlin without incident.

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We place the odds of a smooth election for United Russia at 75%, but a recent series of clumsy top-down reversals points to growing bureaucratic sclerosis—making visible irregularities and a forced late intervention real tail risks even in a scripted race.

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A newly seated Duma, holding one of the few nationwide political mandates left in the system, would play a central role in the event of a political succession, making even marginal shifts in composition worth watching.

September parliamentary election will serve as a loyalty test and a succession-planning mechanism. The State Duma has passed no independently negotiated legislation in two decades, and this election will not change that. Neither will it change the composition of the legislature in any significant way. Yet the vote is still worth watching for two reasons.

First, the Duma vote will function as a nationwide loyalty and stability test primarily for the state bureaucracy. Unlike a totalitarian state, which demands enthusiastic support from all citizens, an authoritarian system like President Vladimir Putin's Russia demands loyalty from the population it feeds—state employees, pensioners, bureaucrats—and passive acquiescence from everyone else. Remote electronic voting, expanded from seven regions in 2021 to 33 now, verifies that loyalty at the workplace level. Hundreds of thousands of local officials, school administrators, and election commissioners are in effect graded on delivering a clean, scandal-free process.

The second reason is Putin's age. He turns 74 on 7 October and has never named a successor; many of the officials who would manage any transition are also in their seventies. Article 92 of the constitution hands power temporarily to the prime minister, currently Mikhail Mishustin, if Putin dies, resigns, or becomes permanently incapacitated, pending a snap election within three months. The new Duma would have to confirm any transitional cabinet and would likely be asked to ratify whatever arrangement Russia's competing security-service and technocratic factions settle on among themselves.

The vote is a litmus test of the effectiveness of the state bureaucracy in an increasingly rigid system. The same apparatus that could once be trusted to produce smooth political outcomes at every level is now visibly straining. Local or mid-level approval used to be a reliable predictor of what would follow. It no longer is, and the rules are becoming more blurred as the system grows more centralized around a single decision-maker.

Three cases in August provide signs of the system's sclerosis, as the top overrides decisions the system has produced at lower levels. Yabloko, Russia's oldest liberal party and the only one of the 17 parties in this race calling for peace, was registered to participate in the election by the Central Election Commission, then disqualified by the Supreme Court on 10 August, five weeks before the vote, over unlicensed photographs, AI-generated artwork, and use of the phrase "no war."

Andrei Klepach, chief economist at the state development bank VEB, said at a closed seminar in May that Russia was struggling in its economic war of attrition; the remarks drew no response for three months until they were reported publicly in mid-August, at which point he was fired within days. St. Petersburg's Gazprom Arena signed a contract for two Kanye West concerts, sold tickets, and then disavowed the arrangement on 24 August; the promoter is disputing the cancellation.

A weaker showing for the ruling party would change little, but could offer insight into public sentiment. The war and its costs have eroded the authorities' popularity; whether that erosion shows up as Russians giving their vote to any of the systemic opposition parties, rather than withholding it or voting United Russia by default, is a real test of how much room the state has left for even symbolic dissent.

Who does not end up in the new Duma matters as much as who does. It is worth watching whether genuine war veterans enter as a new elite cohort; their absence would suggest the system cannot tolerate even a token of unpredictability. It will also be significant whether wealthy or asset-holding figures avoid running altogether—a Duma seat no longer shields against arrest or asset seizure, and increasingly raises sanctions exposure.

We place the odds of the Duma election proceeding smoothly at 75%. The most likely outcome is that events unfold as Putin intends: United Russia's declared party-list vote reaches the high 50s to low 60s (in percent of the vote), turnout stands at about 55%-60% against an official 65% target, and no single incident forces a visible correction during voting. We see a 20% probability of a significant complication—a dispute over the electronic voting system, a contested recount, an opposition-related scandal—forcing a late intervention similar to Yabloko's removal, with negative coverage but no change to the outcome.

We assign the remaining 5% to a scenario in which unexpected underperformance in an urban stronghold, open elite dissent, or a security incident meaningfully dents the managed-majority narrative.

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